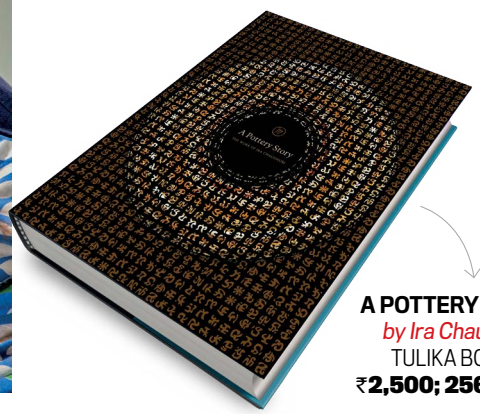




A POTTERY STORY
by Ira Chaudhuri
TULIKA BOOKS
₹2,500; 256 pages

BOOKS

POTTERING ABOUT

A POTTERY STORY COMMEMORATES THE WORK OF MASTER POTTER **IRA CHAUDHURI** OVER SEVEN DECADES

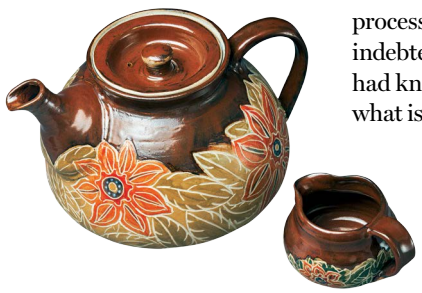
What does a pioneering master potter do after she stops throwing pots post-pandemic? For the past 3-4 years, Ira Chaudhuri, 96, has been making drawings—mostly decorative. She made 300 bookmarks when her book—*A Pottery Story: The Work of Ira Chaudhuri*—was launched last November at the India International Centre in New Delhi. The book traces her distinguished career and, parallelly, the development of Indian studio pottery in Ira's own words and those of her colleague Trupti Patel, besides a conversation with artist Nilima Sheikh.

The gorgeous tome has lavish colour spreads that show Ira at work, and also gets up close with the simple and bold shapes she created in the entire range of shades from austere greys and creams to warm browns, dusky indigos, smouldering vermilions and vitreous turquoises. She often ornamented her pots in the sgraffito technique—fantastical hybrid forms echoing avian, animal and floral shapes and Santiniketan *alpana* that reflect the enigma of Rabindranath Tagore's doodles. Ira lavished her creations with calligraphy in a faux script as well. Jokingly, she calls the script "Iramese".

Asked about the current state of studio pottery in India, sharp as ever, Ira says: "More people are doing ceramic sculpture—non-functional forms—than studio pottery." Referring to the art versus craft controversy, she continues: "Things are leaning towards what they consider art, rather than utilitarian", quipping: "Some people think they can become sculptors overnight!"

The pioneering potter writes that her "greatest inspiration...has been folk and tribal design—Indian, pre-Columbian, Oceanic..." Having started at a time when "our collective ignorance about studio pottery was phenomenal", she did not hesitate to apply school chemistry and arithmetic to make glazes or even consult commercial units.

Ira Chaudhuri was born in Calcutta in 1927. Her father Jehangir Vakil taught English at Santiniketan between 1924 and 1929. It was a time when Santiniketan was trying to forge an identity of its own not only in education but in the field of the arts as well. That spirit was instilled into Ira. After her Intermediate in Mumbai, she joined Kala Bhavan, choosing painting as her subject. It was here that she was introduced to pottery, although Santiniketan had no pottery department. But she would walk to Sriniketan where local people were taught carpentry, weaving and pottery for rural development. But it was "totally commercial", says Ira.



She was no natural potter. She had no fascination for clay either. "I started willy-nilly. Once I got into it, I was addicted. I am not a very strong-willed person. I gave up and took it up once again," Ira had said in an earlier interview.

In 1951, she followed her husband, sculptor Sankho Chaudhuri, to Baroda, where he set up the sculpture department of MS University. With Sankho's encouragement, she learnt pottery by trial and error. All that changed when Basab Kumar Barua, who had trained under giants Bernard Leach and Shoji Hamada, joined Baroda, and the department flourished. Ira's first one-person show happened at Lalit Kala Akademi's Garhi studio in 1979 when they shifted to Delhi. Her life has been a long learning process and she admits she is indebted to every potter she had known. She is convinced what is useful isn't inferior. ■

–Soumitra Das